

Super Humans vs Dispensable People

The augmentation gap and the risk of civilisational dualism



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ABSTRACT

This white paper analyses the gap opening between those adopting cognitive, agential and physical augmentation technologies —the **super humans**— and those left behind —the **dispensable people**. It argues this gap is not marginal but structural and, without active policies, could generate a civilisational dualism without precedent in the twenty-first century. The **operational humanity** model is introduced as a measurement tool: a three-dimension index —access, mastery and autonomy— locating a population on a continuous spectrum between the two extremes. Economic consequences (productivity, labour market), social ones (educational and health stratification) and ethical ones (dignity, rights) are discussed. Eight specific public policies are proposed to prevent mass dispensability, with emphasis on Latin American conditions.

Keywords: Super humans · Dispensable people · Augmentation gap · Civilisational dualism · Operational humanity · AI public policy · Cognitive inequality · Latin America

“The real threat of augmentation is not that some humans become more. It is that others, through political omission, become less.”

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction

The history of technology is the history of unequal access. Every major technical leap produced, in its first phase, a stratification between those with early access and those without. Electricity, the automobile, the telephone, the internet: all followed the same pattern of differential diffusion. The question is whether human augmentation —cognitive, agential and physical— will behave as just another technology or has something qualitatively different.

I have argued in various forums that it has something different. Human augmentation is not a technology one possesses; it is a technology one *is*. That changes the entire political calculus.

2. Operational definitions

A **super human** is defined as a person who persistently combines at least three of the following conditions: (i) a high-capability personal AI agent accompanying them throughout their full working day; (ii) access to relevant physical or sensory extensions (exoskeleton, advanced prosthesis, limited or full BCI); (iii) active mastery of the cognitive competencies needed to operate the ensemble; (iv) a favourable institutional framework recognising their condition.

Dispensable people is defined, in a technical and non-derogatory sense, as the population the agentified productive system can entirely substitute without operational cost. They are not dispensable in moral terms —no person is— but in narrowly economic terms, and precisely for that reason they require active political protection.

3. The operational humanity model

To avoid binarism and enable empirical measurement, I propose the **operational humanity** model, articulated on three dimensions: **access** (effective availability of augmentation tools, not their mere market existence); **mastery** (competence to use them judiciously); and **autonomy** (capacity to operate without them when necessary, avoiding structural dependence).

Each dimension is measured on a 0-100 scale. The aggregate index, simple average or context-weighted, locates a population on a continuous spectrum. A pure super human would show high access, high mastery and high autonomy. A human at risk of dispensability would show the three low. Critically, there are two problematic quadrants: high access with low mastery (blind dependence) and low access with high mastery (competent frustration). Public policy must attend to these quadrants as carefully as to the extremes.

4. Economic analysis

In purely productive terms, a super human generates, in cognitively intensive sectors, between three and ten times the output of an unaugmented human. That asymmetry, if sustained, makes the opportunity cost of not hiring the super human prohibitive, which compresses the labour market for the unaugmented.

The mechanism is not new —it occurred with every previous technological wave— but the speed and magnitude are. Where agricultural mechanisation took decades to redistribute employment, cognitive agentification operates in years.

5. Social analysis

Stratification is not only occupational. In education, students with access to high-quality personal agents reach advanced curricula in a fraction of the time of their peers without access. In health, patients arriving at consultation with an agential pre-diagnosis obtain better effective care, not through privilege, but because they interrogate the system better.

This stratification, if allowed to consolidate without active policy, produces a historically novel phenomenon: a segmentation of the population that is neither of class, nor race, nor gender, but of *augmented operational capacity*. It is a segmentation transversal to the previous ones and therefore has the potential to reshape the entire social map.

6. Ethical analysis

Does a person have a right not to augment themselves? Does a person have a right to augment themselves to the maximum? Contemporary political philosophy has not yet produced a satisfactory framework. I argue that both rights must be preserved, but with a guaranteed minimum floor: no person should fall below a threshold of operational humanity that condemns them to structural dispensability.

That minimum floor is the contemporary formulation of dignity. The ethical question of the period is not whether humans may augment themselves, but what we owe to those who choose not to or cannot.

7. Risk of civilisational dualism

If the process is released to the pure market, the scenario toward 2040 is ominous: two populations coexisting in the same territory but inhabiting two almost disjoint productive, educational, health and agential systems. A super human population operates the agentified economy and captures its surplus. A dispensable population receives passive transfers and loses political voice.

Historically there is no stable precedent of such a dualism. What approximates it are colonial systems, apartheid societies, late feudalisms. All collapsed, usually violently. The historical warning is clear.

8. Public policy and LATAM conclusion

I propose eight concrete policies for Latin America: (i) a publicly funded universal minimum personal agent; (ii) compulsory school curriculum in agential competencies from primary level; (iii) algorithmic audit of the labour market to prevent augmentation discrimination; (iv) mass retraining funded by contributions on agential productivity; (v) specific labour protection for sectors in accelerated transition; (vi) antitrust regulation of the agent market; (vii) health network with egalitarian agential assistance; (viii) distributive impact registry for every significant public agential deployment.

From the **Chris Meniw Foundation Inc.** we drive this framework as a regional agenda, in dialogue with the productive experience of **ZOE IA**, which shows that well-governed agentification can operate as a platform of mass augmentation, not as a mechanism of exclusion. The civilisational choice is not taken in the abstract; it is taken in every public procurement, every educational reform, every health

investment decision. The next decade will determine whether Latin America enters the agentified twenty-first century as a humanly integrated region or as a civilisationally split one.

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